

Licious

India's first D2C unicorn in fresh meat & seafood · Founded 2015 · Bengaluru

Company Background & Origin

Licious (owned by Delightful Gourmet Pvt. Ltd.) was born from a personal frustration: two meat-loving professionals could not find consistently fresh, hygienic meat anywhere in India's sprawling but unorganised retail ecosystem.

Abhay Hanjura : Co-founder & CEO

Background in biotechnology. Left a stable corporate career after identifying that India's meat supply chain was structurally broken — high consumption, zero quality assurance. His scientific background directly shaped Licious's obsession with cold-chain precision.

Vivek Gupta : Co-founder & COO

Finance professional. The founding idea crystallised over a shared lunch where the quality of chicken they were eating was unacceptably poor. His quote: "Why is the most-loved food in India being treated like a stepchild in the retail ecosystem?" defined the company's mission.

Approximately 72–73% of Indians consumed meat and seafood regularly, yet virtually all supply was unorganised wet markets, local butchers, no cold storage, no traceability, inconsistent hygiene. The founders identified this as a classic trust-deficit market ripe for a branded, technology-enabled alternative.

Mission & vision

Mission: To provide Indian consumers with fresh, high-quality, hygienically processed meat and seafood delivered to their doorstep — consistently and conveniently.

Vision: To become India's most trusted protein brand — not merely the best online meat seller — through value-added products, omnichannel retail, and complete supply-chain control.

Early challenges

Cold-chain void: India had no consumer-grade cold-chain for fresh meat. Licious built proprietary IoT-monitored refrigerated infrastructure from scratch.

Consumer trust barrier: Convincing urban consumers to abandon their local butcher for an unknown app required heavy brand investment and visible quality guarantees.

SKU complexity: Fresh meat demands sub-4°C temperature control, short shelf lives (often <48 hours), and city-level food-safety compliance — far more operationally intense than dry grocery.

Investor hesitancy: Early VCs viewed the category as too physical, too capital-intensive, and too "messy" for a tech startup playbook.

Founder-delivered first orders: The company started with approximately 4 orders per day, with Hanjura and Gupta personally delivering to customers in Bengaluru.

Turning Points

Turning point 1 — Series C & cold-chain moat (2018–19)

Using Series C capital (~₹160 Cr), Licious made a deliberately capital-heavy bet that most competitors avoided: building its own chilled processing facilities, refrigerated last-mile fleets, and IoT-monitored cold storage. Outsourcing logistics was the industry norm; owning it became Licious's structural moat. No product was allowed to exceed 4°C from farm to doorstep. By the time rivals recognised this advantage, the infrastructure gap was several years and hundreds of crores wide.

Turning point 2 — COVID-19 demand acceleration (2020–21)

Lockdowns forced millions of consumers who had always bought from wet markets to try online meat delivery for the first time. Licious — already holding the only credible cold-chain infrastructure at scale — reported 500% growth in the 12 months preceding its July 2021 raise, crossing 2 million unique customers. Critically, this was not just a volume event: it permanently shifted consumer behaviour and cemented the brand as synonymous with safe, hygienic

meat at a moment when hygiene anxiety was at its peak. Competitors without equivalent infrastructure could not absorb the surge.

Turning point 3 — Unicorn status & the profitability pivot (2021–24)

In October 2021, a \$52M round pushed Licious past \$1B valuation, making it India's 29th unicorn and the first ever from the D2C food segment. However, post-pandemic growth normalised sharply. Losses reached ₹856 Cr in FY22. Management executed a deliberate pivot from "breadth" to "depth" in 2023–24: exiting low-margin third-party channels (Dunzo, Swiggy Meatstore), halting aggressive new-city expansion, and focusing capital on unit economics in existing markets. The result: losses fell 44% to ₹294 Cr in FY24 and 27% further to ₹218 Cr in FY25, setting up the FY26 revenue record of ₹1,166 Cr.

First Big Achievement

India's first D2C unicorn, October 5, 2021 — a milestone that validated an entirely new consumer category and proved that a branded, technology-enabled cold chain could command premium valuation in a commodity-perceived market.

UNICORN VALUATION \$1B Oct 2021	UNIQUE CUSTOMERS 2M+ Delivered to	12-MONTH GROWTH 500% Prior to raise	THROUGHPUT 9,000 kg Per hour by 2021
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4. Expansion Journey

Licious followed a deliberate, infrastructure-first city rollout, never entering a market without a functioning cold-chain hub in place and a parallel product journey from raw commodity to curated protein brand.

2015

Bengaluru launch - 4 orders/day

Founders personally delivered. SKUs: chicken and mutton only. Delightful Gourmet Pvt. Ltd. incorporated. Cold-chain infrastructure being designed.

2016–17

Hyderabad & Delhi NCR expansion

2nd and 3rd city launches. Seafood and pork added. Processing hubs established per city. Series A and Series B funding secured.

2018–19

Pune, Mumbai, Chennai · 6 cities

Series C (~₹160 Cr) deployed entirely into proprietary cold-chain infrastructure. Ready-to-marinate and ready-to-cook SKUs launched. Innoven Capital joins.

2019–20

Portfolio deepening · Series D/E

Cold cuts, premium seafood, eggs added. Multiples PE invests. Company building technology stack for demand forecasting and inventory optimisation.

2020–21

COVID surge · 15+ cities · 500% growth

Largest demand acceleration in company history. 2M+ unique customers. 9,000 kg/hour throughput. \$192M Series F (Jul) + \$52M Series F-II (Oct, unicorn). Ready-to-eat meals added.

2022

\$150M Series F-III · plant-based · offline

Raised from Amansa Capital, Axis, Kotak. Launched UnCrave (plant-based meat). First offline experience centre opened in Bengaluru (June). Pet food: invested in Pawfectly Made seed round. Expanded to 20+ cities.

2023–24

Depth pivot · My Chicken and More acquisition

Halted aggressive city expansion. Exited Dunzo and Swiggy Meatstore channels. Acquired Bengaluru-based My Chicken and More (22 stores) in Oct 2024, taking physical PoS to 26. Losses cut 44% to ₹294 Cr.

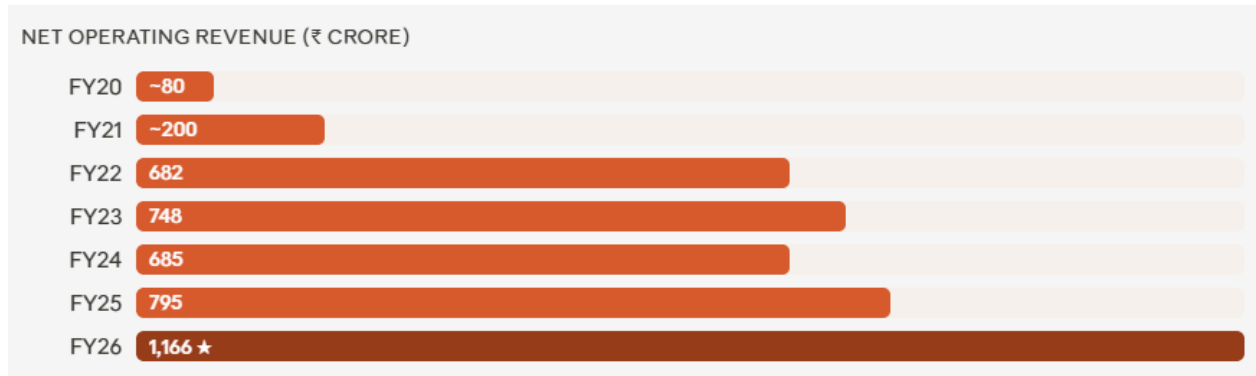
2025–26

Omnichannel · micro-markets · IPO prep

FY26 revenue ₹1,166 Cr (+47%). 60+ stores. 130 dark stores. Monthly revenue crosses ₹100 Cr for first time (Nov 2025). Infinity subscribers: 3.2 lakh, 87%

renewal. IPO targeted at \$2B+ valuation. Quick-commerce: Blinkit & Instamart partnerships growing 35% YoY.

5. Revenue



6. Unique Business Strategies

1. Farm-to-Fork Model

Owns sourcing, processing, packaging, and delivery, ensuring better quality control and freshness.

2. Branding an Unorganized Category

Turned meat from a commodity into a trusted brand by focusing on hygiene, quality, and convenience.

3. Premium Positioning

Competes on quality and trust rather than discounts, allowing higher customer loyalty and margins.

4. "Fresh, Never Frozen" Promise

Created a strong brand identity around freshness, differentiating itself from traditional meat sellers.

5. Ready-to-Cook Products

Expanded beyond raw meat into marinades, kebabs, cold cuts, and ready-to-cook offerings, increasing margins and order value.

6. Omnichannel Expansion

Moved from a pure online model to a mix of online, offline stores, and quick-commerce partnerships.

7. Data-Driven Retention

Focused heavily on repeat purchases through personalization, CRM, and customer loyalty initiatives.

8. Protein Brand Vision

Evolving from a meat-delivery company into a broader protein-focused brand, similar to how Amul dominates dairy.

Key Takeaway: Licious' biggest innovation was not selling meat online—it was building trust and standardization in a highly unorganized industry.